

Walking THE TALK

The Thimpu thaw brings the two estranged neighbours back to the dialogue table with a new template of talks but bridging the trust deficit is not going to be easy

By Saurabh Shukla

Prime Minister Manmohan Singh has three goals he would like to leave behind as his legacy. Two of them, the economic reforms programme and the Indo-US nuclear deal have been achieved with some element of permanence. The third, lasting peace with Pakistan, may prove more elusive in UPA II, but not for want of trying. Last month, at Bhutan's capital Thimpu for the SAARC summit, he had a clear agenda: to find a way to bridge the trust deficit between South Asia's most intractable foes. And when he began a long walkabout with his Pakistani counterpart Yousaf Raza Gilani, something the usually shy prime minister is not used to, he spoke his mind. Later, during a one-hour meeting, much of it without any aide, he gave a clear indication that he is willing to experiment with a new template of talks with Pakistan.

Repairing the Pakistan relationship stems from a combination of beliefs for Manmohan. The first is pragmatism. To achieve 10 per cent growth rate, India has to have peace in the neighbourhood. The other is the emotional element. He was born in Pakistan and there is a desire to go back to Pakistan in an atmosphere of peace. But conscious that his past efforts at Havana and Sharm el-Sheikh led to a domestic uproar, this time his key advisers insist that it will not be business as usual till Pakistan backs its assurance with some credible steps on terrorism.

**MANMOHAN AND GILANI DO A WALKABOUT
DURING THE SAARC SUMMIT AT THIMPU**



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